

In chapter two of *The Concept of Anxiety*, Søren Kierkegaard makes the argument that Adam's first sin would have needed to be different than all others, otherwise, "the concept cancels out" (40). What does Kierkegaard mean by this exactly? He believes that sin is a preexisting condition for sinfulness, while others seem to settle on the opposing view – sinfulness comes before sin. Regarding Adam, Kierkegaard prefers his own interpretation: "through the first sin, sinfulness entered Adam." (40) It's no easy task to explain how sin lays the framework for sinfulness, let alone how Adam's first sin is his and his alone. We need to understand that it is believed that Adam was innocent before he sinned, and that our sinfulness is a consequence of his first sin. Insofar as my mind understands, Kierkegaard holds the stance of superior intrigue here, however his idea of what seems to be sin itself *canceling out* needs to be elaborated upon. Kierkegaard's approach involving the anxiety of Adam and his first sin, and its connection to us, will be addressed, followed by how sinfulness, much like the word itself, comes from sin, and if it were the other way around, the concept would cease to exist.

To put it plainly, Kierkegaard is attempting to detach Adam from the idea of it being his fault that we all sin. He says, "that sin came into the world is quite true, but this is no concern of Adam's." (40) It seems that Kierkegaard would be correct in making the observation that we all are met with the idea of a *first sin*, much like Adam was, but that our first sins all differ from each other; even if for those of us sharing the same first sin – we could have all experienced different conditions leading to that sin. So, if we all have a first sin, then it is no more Adam's fault than that of say, one of our friend's... unless of course a friend leads us to commit an act that some may call a *sin*. Even then, Kierkegaard would argue that it is more of the mind realizing that it has the "possibility of possibility" (51) – his attempt at defining anxiety, which generally leads to a decision of some sort. And this is what makes Adam not different, but the

same as us all. The fact that Adam experienced anxiety led him to sin, which then leaked sinfulness into his world, not our world – it wouldn't even be correct to say *the world*. His sin was caused by the ability to choose, which he had before touching the tree. It's no different than any one of us being told to not do something. When this happens, we realize that we can do this *something* just as much as we don't have to do it – we are experiencing anxiety, which in itself is a fairly universal feeling. So, then it would make more sense to say that Adam is the first one to experience anxiety, a feeling that anyone not a beast (to borrow a term from Kierkegaard) is capable of experiencing. It just so happens that sometimes our anxiety, albeit our choice to choose, results in what is referred to as sinning.

Kierkegaard exhausts that “it is through the first sin that sin came into the world.” (38) Here it needs to be emphasized that when he says “the world” (38), he means the immediate world that is Adam's. Sure the idea of sin can be dated back to Adam, but it was just as new a concept to him as it is to anyone having yet to be confronted with it. As Kierkegaard states, “...it would not occur to us to say about any later person that it was through his sin that sinfulness came into the world” (40), so logically then we are forced to no longer attach this burden to Adam.

For one to have sinfulness, one would need to sin, and even when reversed it works in Kierkegaard's favor: when someone sins they are filling their meter of sinfulness, so to speak. Otherwise there is an underlying assumption that because one has sinfulness, it will lead them to sin – and this isn't necessarily true. To think that sinfulness is some property that we all have before we actually sin seems contradictory due to the fact that as previously stated, one can only have sinfulness after having sinned. So, if we all have sinfulness before having sinned, then there must be another reason for this, and this reason is that because Adam sinned, we now hold some

degree of sinfulness. But Kierkegaard's view was just strengthened on the grounds that Adam's sin was that of his own, and that we are all responsible for our own sinfulness after having our own first sin. If things were in support of the former view, then everything would be absolutely contradictory, and would therefore 'cease to exist'.